

Q Can my baby have normal formula?

If you want to give your premature baby formula, she will need to have special type of formula that contains additional amounts of nutrients, calories, and essential fats. Your hospital will provide this for you while you are there. When your baby has reached the due date, and is ready to go home, the hospital will probably prescribe this special high-calorie formula and recommend that she continues on this until she has reached a certain weight and is well enough to go onto ordinary formula. Don't switch formula without consulting your doctor first.

Latching on Be patient when you start to offer your premature baby a breast-feeding, and give her plenty of time to practice latching on.



Q How can I help support my baby's development and growth once she's home?

It's reassuring to know that most premature babies will usually catch up to be at least almost as tall, strong, and heavy as their classmates by the time they are four years old. This is because premature babies have two "catch-up" growth spurts (see below) that bring them in line with their peers. For your part, making sure your baby is well nourished is essential for triggering these growth spurts.



The first months

Your medical team will discharge your baby from the hospital once they are confident that she is gaining weight. If you are breast-feeding, continue to do so on demand. If you are formula-feeding, follow the advice your doctor gives you about pacing feedings. Breast-fed babies (and some formula-fed ones) need vitamin and mineral supplements to ensure they receive extra dosages of all the nutrients they need for development. Your baby may need to continue taking these until she is a year old.



Catch-up growth spurts

Between the ages of one and two years, your child may have catch-up growth spurts—this will be apparent first from an increase in her head circumference recorded on her growth chart, followed by a sharp rise in her length and weight—she may quickly start to grow out of her clothes! She may have another small catch-up growth spurt at about three years old. After this time, she will be roughly the same height and weight as all the other children her age.



Starting solid food

Although advice is that babies should start solids at around six months, for premature babies this means six months from their due date rather than their actual age. So, if your baby was four weeks premature, you would wait until she is seven months old before starting solids, when her digestive system will be mature enough to digest solid food. If your baby was very premature or you are in any doubt about when to start her on solids, the doctors who take care of your baby can guide you.



Other ways to help

» **Encouraging good sleeping patterns—and, over time, teaching your baby to soothe herself to sleep**—will help your baby to grow and develop. Studies show that premature babies who sleep deeply in kangaroo care (see p.313) grow and develop faster than those who don't have this experience.

» **As your baby grows, periods of activity every day** will help improve her muscle tone and skeletal strength, which in turn will help to maximize her growth.